power vacuum in Afghanistan is unlikely, the possibility of negative forces inimical to India pursuing their interests through the SCO mechanism remains a worry. The China–Afghanistan–Pakistan foreign ministers' dialogue mechanism to get the Afghan Taliban to join the reconciliation process is worrisome for India. Afghanistan has also pledged closer cooperation with China on the Belt and Road Initiative, and Afghan President Ghani has cherished Afghanistan's friendship with China.[8] To what extent India can play a role in formulating a regional consensus on an Afghan peace proposal under the SCO is an important issue. It is possible that India and China might eventually find it imperative to collaborate in Afghanistan.

Seventh, SCO membership could give India a new way to build promising bridges with Central Asia while maintaining its emphasis on reaching out to this region through direct bilateral channels. This includes cooperation in sectors such as information technology (IT), banks, and finance. India could furthermore engage in soft political areas of the region through participation in education, environmental protection, disaster management and rescue operations, climate change, water-related issues, and people-to-people contacts. India brings decades of experience in dealing with social issues, especially in multiethnic, multireligious, and multicultural settings, that it can share with the SCO member states confronted with these challenges. India's liberal-democratic values could also serve as an alternative in building civil societies, pluralistic structures, ethno-religious harmony, and the rule of law. Central Asian states, however, fluctuate regularly in line with their interests and ably play suitors off each other to extract economic benefits and reinforce political control at home. India needs to build its own leverages with these countries to be an effective member of the SCO and at the same time avoid the risk of becoming a focal point of criticism by Central Asian states.